# Crocs: Using Community-Centric Marketing to Make Ugly Iconic

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## Introduction Summary

Crocs, once ridiculed for its unconventional design, has transformed into one of the most recognizable and fastest-growing footwear brands in the world. Through bold marketing campaigns, celebrity collaborations, and community-focused engagement, the company turned its once “ugly” image into a symbol of individuality and comfort. Despite its remarkable comeback, Crocs now faces the challenge of sustaining its momentum and remaining relevant in an ever-changing fashion landscape while balancing growth, innovation, and brand authenticity.

## Primary Definition

**Primary issue:** The primary issue facing Crocs is how to sustain its unprecedented resurgence and maintain long-term relevance in an industry driven by fast-changing fashion trends and consumer perceptions. After being mocked for its unattractive design and nearly collapsing in the late 2000s, Crocs rebuilt its brand through strategic refocusing on its iconic Classic Clog, community-driven marketing, and influencer collaborations that made the “ugly” aesthetic fashionable again. However, with success rooted heavily in cultural trends, celebrity endorsements, and viral marketing, Crocs now faces the strategic challenge of ensuring its popularity is not just another fad. The company must balance innovation and diversification—particularly as it expands into international markets and new product categories like sandals—while staying true to its core identity. Achieving sustained growth requires Crocs to translate short-term buzz and social media virality into enduring brand loyalty and consistent global sales.

**Secondary issue:** Several secondary issues underpin this main challenge. First, Crocs must manage brand perception to remain appealing to both its traditional “Feel Good” comfort-oriented customers and its newer, younger “Explorer” segment that values fashion and self-expression. This balancing act risks alienating one group while chasing another. Second, as the company continues to rely on collaborations and social media campaigns, it faces the danger of market saturation and diminishing returns from overexposure. Additionally, its dependence on external manufacturing and international supply chains introduces risks tied to quality control, production costs, and sustainability commitments. Crocs’ pledge to reach net-zero emissions by 2040 and adopt eco-friendly materials adds another layer of operational and reputational complexity. Finally, with digital sales and metaverse initiatives becoming central to its marketing strategy, Crocs must ensure these innovations genuinely enhance consumer engagement rather than serve as fleeting trends. Altogether, these secondary issues test Crocs’ ability to evolve from a cultural phenomenon into a stable, enduring global brand.

## Situation and Positioning

How Crocs Got Here & What They Do Well: Crocs started out making boat shoes. They used this cool material called Croslite – it's light, floats, and is easy to clean. Plus, they had a supply chain that allowed them to grow fast. But after growing too big and the 2008-09 financial crisis,

the people in charge went back to focusing on their Classic Clog. They also moved all their manufacturing overseas in 2018 and closed some stores.

What Crocs Stands For: They're all about comfort, color, fun, and being yourself. You can spot their clogs anywhere. Jibbitz allows you to decorate them however you want. Their Come As You Are thing is about being unique, even if some people think they're ugly. Their basic clogs usually cost around $50, but special designs can cost more.

Who Crocs Are For: They have two main groups of customers. One group just wants comfy, useful shoes for the whole family. The other group is younger people who care about fashion and love to personalize their stuff. The second group is bigger in places where Crocs are starting to get really popular.

**Alternatives**

Crocs' leadership explored several strategic alternatives to sustain business growth and protect its renewed brand image. The first option was to deepen community-centric marketing, the approach that fueled Crocs' revival. Led by CMO Heidi Cooley, this strategy emphasized authentic engagement with real fans instead of traditional advertising. Through *social listening* and *community seeding*, Crocs identified consumers already wearing or posting about the brand and turned them into advocates by sharing their stories or gifting them personalized pairs. This strengthened authenticity and emotional loyalty but required significant effort to scale globally. The second alternative, promoted by CEO Andrew Rees, was to expand the product portfolio and fashion collaborations. By introducing new styles and continuing limited-edition partnerships with designers like Balenciaga and Post Malone, Crocs could maintain excitement and drive revenue growth. However, over-expansion risked diluting the brand's identity and over-reliance on hype. A third option was to refocus on comfort and functionality, highlighting Crocs' ergonomic design for healthcare and everyday wear. This would ensure stable sales but could undermine the fashion credibility and cultural momentum the brand had built. Finally, Crocs could scale globally through localized community marketing, adapting its "Come As You Are" message to regional audiences and partnering with local influencers. While this would diversify revenue and strengthen global presence, maintaining consistent authenticity across markets could be challenging.

**Qualitative Support**

Crocs' turnaround was driven largely by qualitative factors related to consumer perception, brand authenticity, and emotional connection. The company's success stemmed from its ability to transform negative public sentiment into a celebration of individuality. By embracing its "ugly but comfortable" identity, Crocs connected with consumers who valued self-expression over conformity. The brand's community-centric marketing approach played a crucial role. Instead of relying on traditional advertising, Crocs built relationships with real fans and micro-influencers who genuinely loved the product. The company practiced social listening, identifying users who

posted about Crocs on social media and engaging them directly through personalized interactions or collaborations. These organic connections strengthened authenticity and made consumers feel seen and valued. Additionally, Crocs' partnerships with cultural icons and fashion designers — such as Balenciaga, Post Malone, and Salehe Bembury — added credibility and made the brand culturally relevant without abandoning its core comfort positioning. The "Come As You Are" campaign further reinforced inclusivity and individuality, resonating deeply with Gen Z and younger consumers who value authenticity over perfection. Together, these qualitative factors demonstrate that Crocs' resurgence was not just a result of product changes or revenue strategies, but of a strong emotional bond with consumers built through community, creativity, and cultural engagement.

**Quantitative Support**

Crocs as company grew incredibly fast! Sales jumped from around $2.3 billion to $3.6 billion, selling over 115 million pairs – that's like 4 pairs every second! Their goal is to hit $5 billion someday. Key to that are doing better overseas, selling more sandals, and focusing on sustainability. Their prices are set up so the basic clogs cost about $50. Some special edition shoes sell for way more, making shoe accessible to everyone but still have limited-edition shoes. Those little Jibbitz things make up about 8% of sales and folks who buy them tend to buy more stuff overall. Sandals brought in around $310 million in 2022. Even though they don't make as much money on sandals as they do on clogs, people buy them more often, so it helps them sell other products too.

**Recommendations**

To ensure Crocs continues its impressive growth trajectory while safeguarding the authenticity that fueled its revival, the company should pursue a hybrid strategy that blends community-driven engagement, product innovation, sustainable global expansion, and market penetration in emerging regions. The key lies in transforming the brand's short-term cultural relevance into long-term loyalty through deeper emotional connections, diversified offerings, and strategic growth initiatives. Crocs should continue to strengthen its community-centric marketing approach that has proven essential to its success. Rather than over-relying on celebrity endorsements, the brand should double down on authentic storytelling by highlighting real consumer experiences and expanding its "Come As You Are" message into more localized and culturally resonant narratives across different markets. By investing in region-specific influencer collaborations and community initiatives, Crocs can build a more global yet personalized brand identity, one that still feels inclusive and relatable no matter where consumers are. At the same time, product diversification remains vital to sustaining excitement and revenue growth. Crocs should expand its focus beyond the Classic Clog by increasing production and marketing of sandals and other everyday comfort footwear. Sandals have already demonstrated strong sales performance and high purchase frequency, making them a promising complementary product category that can attract new consumers while retaining loyal ones. By leveraging its proprietary

Croslite material and ergonomic design expertise, Crocs can establish a stronger foothold in the broader casual footwear market. Collaborations with designers and brands should continue strategically, emphasizing limited-edition releases that maintain the exclusivity and creativity fans love, without overwhelming the market or diluting the brand's comfort-first identity. A more data-driven approach to monitoring collaboration performance will help identify which partnerships deliver lasting value versus short-lived hype. Additionally, Crocs should pursue mass penetration in emerging markets as a strategic market-share play. This would involve offering lower-priced products and executing high-distribution pushes across regions such as Europe, the Middle East and North Africa (MENA), Latin America, and Asia. By creating localized assortments, collaborating with regional partners, and tailoring marketing to local cultures, Crocs can significantly expand Classic Clog penetration and tap into large, underdeveloped markets with high growth potential. While this approach requires substantial investment in distribution networks, localization efforts, and supply chain scalability which could place some pressure on margins it offers the opportunity to capture a vast total addressable market and build brand presence where awareness remains relatively low. Innovation should also extend beyond product design into sustainability and digital experiences. With its pledge to achieve net-zero emissions by 2040, Crocs should invest in research and partnerships that accelerate the development of bio-based and recycled materials while maintaining quality and comfort. Communicating these sustainability milestones transparently can strengthen credibility among eco-conscious consumers and reinforce the brand's leadership in responsible fashion. Furthermore, as digital engagement becomes increasingly central to consumer behavior, Crocs should enhance its e-commerce and metaverse initiatives to drive meaningful interaction rather than novelty-based exposure. Personalization tools like virtual Jibbitz customization and augmented reality try-ons can elevate customer engagement while collecting insights into evolving preferences. Ultimately, the best path forward for Crocs is to balance trend-driven marketing with timeless brand principles: comfort, self-expression, and authenticity. By scaling its community engagement globally, increasing sandal production alongside clogs, pursuing mass-market penetration in emerging regions, innovating sustainably, and expanding into complementary product lines, Crocs can evolve from a revived pop-culture icon into a consistently relevant global footwear leader.

**Implementation of Recommendations**

**What:** Crocs should continue expanding its *community-centric and collaboration-driven marketing strategy* while strengthening its sustainability initiatives. The focus should be on amplifying personalization through Jibbitz and digital engagement, introducing new product lines (like sandals and eco-friendly clogs), and growing international sales in markets such as Asia, Europe, and Latin America. This recommendation aims to maintain the brand's "Come As You Are" identity while evolving it to align with global trends and sustainability goals

**Where:** The implementation will primarily take place in Crocs' *core global markets* the U.S., China, Japan, South Korea, Germany, and the U.K. as well as emerging markets in *Asia, the*

*Middle East, and Latin America*, where "Explorer" consumers represent strong growth potential. Crocs can leverage its existing digital platforms, e-commerce site, and new app to support this expansion.

**Who:** Key responsibility falls on *Crocs' executive team*, led by CEO Andrew Rees and CMO Heidi Cooley, alongside the *digital marketing, product innovation, and sustainability departments*. Influencer partners and collaborators (artists, fashion designers, and cultural figures) will also play a central role in maintaining authenticity. Additionally, local marketing teams in target regions will adapt campaigns to resonate with their cultural contexts.

**When:** Implementation should be rolled out *within the next three years* to align with Crocs' 2026 goal of reaching $5 billion in revenue. The short-term focus (2025–2026) should prioritize expanding sandals and digital initiatives, while the mid-term (by 2030) should center on achieving global sustainability milestones such as net-zero emissions by 2040.

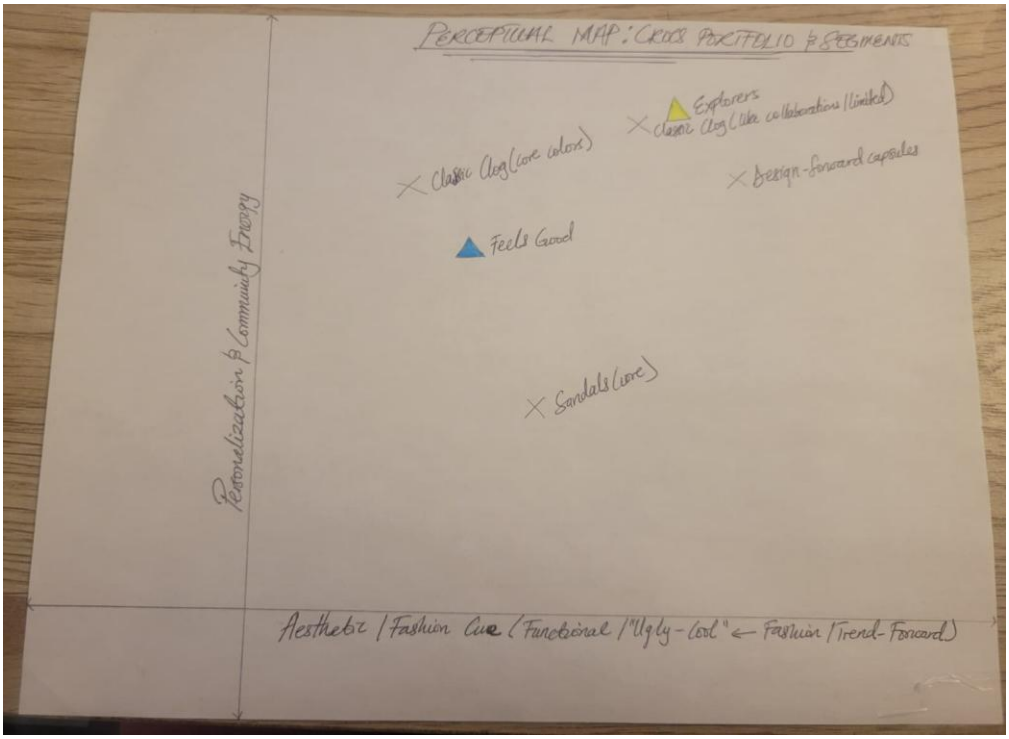
**How:** Crocs will execute this plan through:

- **Digital-first marketing:** Using TikTok, Instagram, and metaverse activations (like Roblox and Minecraft) to increase engagement and UGC.
- **Collaborations:** Partnering with both luxury and pop-culture brands to sustain hype and exclusivity.
- **Personalization:** Expanding the *"Customize Your Crocs"* program and promoting Jibbitz as a creative self-expression tool.
- **Sustainability:** Investing in eco-friendly Croslite materials and sustainable packaging practices.
- **Global distribution:** Leveraging online sales channels and localized influencer marketing to penetrate new markets effectively

**Risk and Metrics**

The main *risks* include *brand fatigue*, as overexposure from frequent collaborations could reduce exclusivity, and *market saturation* in mature regions. Additionally, governance risks may emerge if Crocs' sustainability promises are not met on time, potentially leading to reputational backlash. There are also *experience risks* if digital campaigns fail to resonate globally or seem culturally tone-deaf, especially in international expansions. To mitigate these risks, Crocs should track *key metrics* such as engagement rates on digital campaigns, sales growth by region, percentage of sustainable materials used, and Jibbitz related revenue share. Customer satisfaction surveys, collaboration sell out times, and brand sentiment analysis through social listening will also serve as key indicators. A balanced focus on innovation, cultural authenticity, and sustainability will help ensure Crocs remains relevant and profitable while staying true to its "Come As You Are" identity.

**Appendix A: Perceptual Map**




**References**

Harvard Business School Publishing. (n.d.). *Crocs: Using community-centric marketing to make ugly iconic* (Case No. 9-524-006). Harvard Business School Publishing.